The Hotwells Shipyards in the 1780s

Introduction

The partners wrote to each other even when they lived a mile apart, partly from habit and partly because a letter was a record that could be shown to a court. The reader who comes to these papers expecting the great questions of the age will find instead a very close attention to casks, hoops and freight. The sugar trade of the eighteenth century rested upon credit, and credit rested upon the character of the man who gave it. Credit was extended for months at a time, and a house that called in its debts too sharply would soon find itself without correspondents.

Letters took from five to eight weeks to cross the Atlantic, so that every decision was made on information that was already out of date. The wages of seamen were fixed by the month, and a man discharged abroad had a claim to his pay up to the day of his discharge. The reader who comes to these papers expecting the great questions of the age will find instead a very close attention to casks, hoops and freight. The firm's books were kept in the Italian manner, but the clerks of the period were not always consistent in their treatment of the discount. The wages of seamen were fixed by the month, and a man discharged abroad had a claim to his pay up to the day of his discharge.

The Hotwells yards, a short distance below the city, were able to build for owners from Bristol, Liverpool and London alike. The cooper's trade was as important as the shipwright's, for a cask that leaked was a cargo lost, and the cost fell on the owner. Historians have long debated how far the Bristol houses depended upon the Jamaica planters, and how far the planters upon them. The firm's books were kept in the Italian manner, but the clerks of the period were not always consistent in their treatment of the discount. Where the surviving accounts can be checked against the port books, they are in general remarkably accurate, if rarely complete.

A merchant of Bristol who lost a ship in the autumn might find that his factors in Lisbon had already drawn upon him for the whole of the spring crop. The sugar trade of the eighteenth century rested upon credit, and credit rested upon the character of the man who gave it. Freight rates moved with the season and with the news from Europe, and a rumour of war could double the cost of a voyage within a week. The river Avon, with its great tidal range, shaped the working day of every merchant in the city; ships could move only at the top of the tide. The reader who comes to these papers expecting the great questions of the age will find instead a very close attention to casks, hoops and freight. The partners wrote to each other even when they lived a mile apart, partly from habit and partly because a letter was a record that could be shown to a court.

Some of the most revealing documents in the collection are the least formal: a note about a wet cargo, or a list of things to be bought for a ship. A ship's master was at once a navigator, a trader and a disciplinarian, and the owners trusted him with a good deal more than the sailing of the vessel. Historians have long debated how far the Bristol houses depended upon the Jamaica planters, and how far the planters upon them. The partners wrote to each other even when they lived a mile apart,

partly from habit and partly because a letter was a record that could be shown to a court. The reader who comes to these papers expecting the great questions of the age will find instead a very close attention to casks, hoops and freight. The volume of trade can be estimated from the duties paid, though the figures need to be read with care, since cargoes were often entered at a round number.

The yards on the Avon

What survives is uneven: whole years are missing, and the letters that remain were kept, as often as not, because they recorded a debt. Insurance was dear, and the underwriters of the Exchange coffee house were slow to pay a claim that touched upon the capture of a vessel. Freight rates moved with the season and with the news from Europe, and a rumour of war could double the cost of a voyage within a week. Where the surviving accounts can be checked against the port books, they are in general remarkably accurate, if rarely complete. Some of the most revealing documents in the collection are the least formal: a note about a wet cargo, or a list of things to be bought for a ship. Where the surviving accounts can be checked against the port books, they are in general remarkably accurate, if rarely complete.

Where the surviving accounts can be checked against the port books, they are in general remarkably accurate, if rarely complete. The Hotwells yards, a short distance below the city, were able to build for owners from Bristol, Liverpool and London alike. Seen from the counting house, the abolition debates of the period were at first a distant noise, and only later a matter of direct concern. Seen from the counting house, the abolition debates of the period were at first a distant noise, and only later a matter of direct concern. What survives is uneven: whole years are missing, and the letters that remain were kept, as often as not, because they recorded a debt.

The cooper's trade was as important as the shipwright's, for a cask that leaked was a cargo lost, and the cost fell on the owner. A merchant of Bristol who lost a ship in the autumn might find that his factors in Port Royal had already drawn upon him for the whole of the spring crop. Seen from the counting house, the abolition debates of the period were at first a distant noise, and only later a matter of direct concern. Credit was extended for months at a time, and a house that called in its debts too sharply would soon find itself without correspondents. A ship's master was at once a navigator, a trader and a disciplinarian, and the owners trusted him with a good deal more than the sailing of the vessel.

Freight rates moved with the season and with the news from Europe, and a rumour of war could double the cost of a voyage within a week. Insurance was dear, and the underwriters of the Exchange coffee house were slow to pay a claim that touched upon the capture of a vessel. The Hotwells yards, a short distance below the city, were able to build for owners from Bristol, Liverpool and London alike. A merchant of Bristol who lost a ship in the autumn might find that his factors in Port Royal had already drawn upon him for the whole of the spring crop.

Historians have long debated how far the Bristol houses depended upon the Jamaica planters, and how far the planters upon them. The chapter that follows rests chiefly upon the letters of the years 1783 to 1790, which are the most complete in the collection. Letters took from five to eight weeks to

cross the Atlantic, so that every decision was made on information that was already out of date. The reader who comes to these papers expecting the great questions of the age will find instead a very close attention to casks, hoops and freight.

Seen from the counting house, the abolition debates of the period were at first a distant noise, and only later a matter of direct concern. Credit was extended for months at a time, and a house that called in its debts too sharply would soon find itself without correspondents. A merchant of Bristol who lost a ship in the autumn might find that his factors in Falmouth had already drawn upon him for the whole of the spring crop. The chapter that follows rests chiefly upon the letters of the years 1783 to 1790, which are the most complete in the collection.

Some of the most revealing documents in the collection are the least formal: a note about a wet cargo, or a list of things to be bought for a ship. The river Avon, with its great tidal range, shaped the working day of every merchant in the city; ships could move only at the top of the tide. Historians have long debated how far the Bristol houses depended upon the Jamaica planters, and how far the planters upon them. The wages of seamen were fixed by the month, and a man discharged abroad had a claim to his pay up to the day of his discharge. The river Avon, with its great tidal range, shaped the working day of every merchant in the city; ships could move only at the top of the tide.

Where the surviving accounts can be checked against the port books, they are in general remarkably accurate, if rarely complete. The sugar trade of the eighteenth century rested upon credit, and credit rested upon the character of the man who gave it. The partners wrote to each other even when they lived a mile apart, partly from habit and partly because a letter was a record that could be shown to a court. The firm's books were kept in the Italian manner, but the clerks of the period were not always consistent in their treatment of the discount. The Hotwells yards, a short distance below the city, were able to build for owners from Bristol, Liverpool and London alike.

The cooper's trade was as important as the shipwright's, for a cask that leaked was a cargo lost, and the cost fell on the owner. The correspondence shows a house that was careful rather than bold, and which seldom put more than a third of its capital into any one voyage. The correspondence shows a house that was careful rather than bold, and which seldom put more than a third of its capital into any one voyage. The firm's books were kept in the Italian manner, but the clerks of the period were not always consistent in their treatment of the discount.

The yard of Thomas Boyd

The yard of Thomas Boyd at Hotwells built eleven vessels between 1781 and 1790, the largest of them the 280-ton Africa Packet. The smaller craft, brigs and snows for the Jamaica and Cork trades, were built on the same slip in the winter months, when the demand for repairs was low.

The river Avon, with its great tidal range, shaped the working day of every merchant in the city; ships could move only at the top of the tide. It is the small entries, the cost of a boat or the loan of a lantern, that tell us most about the daily life of the quay. Historians have long debated how far the Bristol houses depended upon the Jamaica planters, and how far the planters upon them. It is the small entries, the cost of a boat or the loan of a lantern, that tell us most about the daily life of the

quay. The Hotwells yards, a short distance below the city, were able to build for owners from Bristol, Liverpool and London alike.

What survives is uneven: whole years are missing, and the letters that remain were kept, as often as not, because they recorded a debt. What survives is uneven: whole years are missing, and the letters that remain were kept, as often as not, because they recorded a debt. The firm's books were kept in the Italian manner, but the clerks of the period were not always consistent in their treatment of the discount. What survives is uneven: whole years are missing, and the letters that remain were kept, as often as not, because they recorded a debt. The volume of trade can be estimated from the duties paid, though the figures need to be read with care, since cargoes were often entered at a round number.

The partners wrote to each other even when they lived a mile apart, partly from habit and partly because a letter was a record that could be shown to a court. The chapter that follows rests chiefly upon the letters of the years 1783 to 1790, which are the most complete in the collection. The chapter that follows rests chiefly upon the letters of the years 1783 to 1790, which are the most complete in the collection. What survives is uneven: whole years are missing, and the letters that remain were kept, as often as not, because they recorded a debt.

A merchant of Bristol who lost a ship in the autumn might find that his factors in Port Royal had already drawn upon him for the whole of the spring crop. Insurance was dear, and the underwriters of the Exchange coffee house were slow to pay a claim that touched upon the capture of a vessel. The firm's books were kept in the Italian manner, but the clerks of the period were not always consistent in their treatment of the discount. The river Avon, with its great tidal range, shaped the working day of every merchant in the city; ships could move only at the top of the tide. Insurance was dear, and the underwriters of the Exchange coffee house were slow to pay a claim that touched upon the capture of a vessel. The firm's books were kept in the Italian manner, but the clerks of the period were not always consistent in their treatment of the discount.

Costs and credit

It is the opinion of the underwriters that the risk to Montego Bay is not increased by the late news, and I have insured accordingly. Freight to Madeira is now £4 15s the ton, and the underwriters at the Exchange ask four per cent for the voyage. The wharfinger asks £35 2s 10d for the landing of the cordage, which I think too much, and I have told him so. A letter from Mr. Withers at Glasgow says that hoops will be taken only at a discount of ten per cent, which I have declined.

It is the opinion of the underwriters that the risk to Port Royal is not increased by the late news, and I have insured accordingly. I have seen Mr. Gadsden at the Exchange, and payment for the logwood is promised before winter. The clerk has copied the bill of lading twice, as Mr. Alleyne would not accept the first for the want of a seal. A letter from Capt. Lyle at London says that rum will be taken only at a discount of four per cent, which I have declined.

If the butter is damp on arrival we shall claim upon the underwriters, and I beg you to have a surveyor's certificate ready. The warehouse in Queen Square is full of cotton, and until the Union is

cleared I cannot receive any more. If the logwood is damp on arrival we shall claim upon the underwriters, and I beg you to have a surveyor's certificate ready. Freight to Port Royal is now £4 5s the ton, and the underwriters at the Exchange ask seven per cent for the voyage. The warehouse in Queen Square is full of candles, and until the Betsey is cleared I cannot receive any more. Your account of the cordage is noted, but the sample you sent was damp, and I would not take more than 71 puncheons on those terms.

If the rum is damp on arrival we shall claim upon the underwriters, and I beg you to have a surveyor's certificate ready. The warehouse in Queen Square is full of cotton, and until the Mary Ann is cleared I cannot receive any more. I have seen Mr. Fuller at the Exchange, and payment for the rum is promised before midsummer. It is the opinion of the underwriters that the risk to Bristol is not increased by the late news, and I have insured accordingly.

A ship's master was at once a navigator, a trader and a disciplinarian, and the owners trusted him with a good deal more than the sailing of the vessel. The chapter that follows rests chiefly upon the letters of the years 1783 to 1790, which are the most complete in the collection. The correspondence shows a house that was careful rather than bold, and which seldom put more than a third of its capital into any one voyage.

Where the surviving accounts can be checked against the port books, they are in general remarkably accurate, if rarely complete. The reader who comes to these papers expecting the great questions of the age will find instead a very close attention to casks, hoops and freight. A ship's master was at once a navigator, a trader and a disciplinarian, and the owners trusted him with a good deal more than the sailing of the vessel. The river Avon, with its great tidal range, shaped the working day of every merchant in the city; ships could move only at the top of the tide.

Conclusion

The sugar trade of the eighteenth century rested upon credit, and credit rested upon the character of the man who gave it. It is the small entries, the cost of a boat or the loan of a lantern, that tell us most about the daily life of the quay. Credit was extended for months at a time, and a house that called in its debts too sharply would soon find itself without correspondents. Insurance was dear, and the underwriters of the Exchange coffee house were slow to pay a claim that touched upon the capture of a vessel. The river Avon, with its great tidal range, shaped the working day of every merchant in the city; ships could move only at the top of the tide.

Letters took from five to eight weeks to cross the Atlantic, so that every decision was made on information that was already out of date. Where the surviving accounts can be checked against the port books, they are in general remarkably accurate, if rarely complete. Freight rates moved with the season and with the news from Europe, and a rumour of war could double the cost of a voyage within a week. Letters took from five to eight weeks to cross the Atlantic, so that every decision was made on information that was already out of date.

The correspondence shows a house that was careful rather than bold, and which seldom put more than a third of its capital into any one voyage. The sugar trade of the eighteenth century rested upon

credit, and credit rested upon the character of the man who gave it. The cooper's trade was as important as the shipwright's, for a cask that leaked was a cargo lost, and the cost fell on the owner. The sugar trade of the eighteenth century rested upon credit, and credit rested upon the character of the man who gave it. Insurance was dear, and the underwriters of the Exchange coffee house were slow to pay a claim that touched upon the capture of a vessel.